

A meteorologist and Arctic explorer, Alfred Wegener was the first to propose a systematic theory of continental drift. Although not trained in geology, he was an original thinker and was able to amass supporting evidence from his wide-ranging research. As with many innovators, his ideas were not accepted until long after his death.

Alfred Wegener was born in Berlin, Germany, the youngest of five children. He completed a PhD in astronomy at Berlin University, then switched to the field of meteorology (the study of weather and climate) and went to work at a meteorological station in the town of Beeskow. It was there that he, together with his brother Kurt, pioneered the use of weather balloons to study air movement.

In 1906, Wegener was given the job of meteorologist on a scientific expedition to chart the northeast coast of Greenland. It was an important learning experience, during which he built the first meteorological station in Greenland. On his return to Germany, he became professor of meteorology at Marburg University, where he began questioning why the continents are shaped the way they are. He had noticed that the coastlines

Wegener's fourth expedition to Greenland, in 1930, was to be his last. Just days after his 50th birthday, he set out across the ice for extra supplies and never returned. The expedition was completed by his brother.

MILESTONES

FOSSIL RECORD

Discovers fossil evidence in 1911 that supports his theory that Africa and South America were once joined.

KEY PUBLICATIONS

Publishes his theory in two papers in 1912, and explains continental drift in a series of lectures.

CAREER INTERRUPTED

Drafted into the German army in World War I, but is released in 1914 after being wounded.

TRAILBLAZING BOOK

Publishes *The Origin of Continents and Oceans* in 1915, with maps of how the continents were joined.

ACADEMIC ROLE

Takes up the post of professor of meteorology and geophysics at Graz University, Austria, in 1924.

